

Guide 61 — Preschool Assistant and Childcare Worker

Controlled English working master — Version 2.0

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What this work is

Preschool assistants and childcare workers help care for children, maintain safe routines, support play and early learning, assist with meals, hygiene and rest, observe children, communicate routine information, and work under employer and jurisdictional rules.

This guide focuses on **support-level childcare and preschool-assistant work**. It does not treat a support worker as automatically equivalent to a licensed or certified early childhood educator, lead preschool teacher, special-education professional, nurse, therapist, social worker, safeguarding authority, or other regulated professional.

In the United States, the closest federal occupational family is **Childcare Workers, O*NET-SOC 39-9011.00**. In Canada, the closest broad mapping is **Early childhood educators and assistants, NOC 42202**. In Colombia, the primary support-role mapping is **CNO 4311 — Auxiliares de educación para la primera infancia**, with **CNO 6372 — Auxiliares del cuidado de niños** as a related childcare-support occupation.

Titles, minimum age, education, background checks, health screening, child-to-staff ratios, first-aid/CPR rules, food handling, medication authority, safeguarding duties, mandatory-reporting obligations, facility licensing, and protected educator titles vary by jurisdiction and setting. Verify the actual job description and current local rules before accepting a position or paying for training.

What you may do

Depending on employer policy, training, supervision, age group, and local law, duties may include:

- supervising children during play, learning, meals, rest, transitions, and outdoor activities;
- preparing age-appropriate materials and helping set up supervised activities;
- reading stories, singing songs, supporting play, and reinforcing routines established by responsible educators or supervisors;

- helping children with handwashing, toileting, dressing, feeding, and other routine care within authorized scope;
- cleaning and organizing toys, tables, learning areas, and approved childcare equipment;
- observing children and recording routine factual information using approved forms or systems;
- helping maintain attendance, sign-in/sign-out, meal, sleep, incident, or activity records when assigned;
- supporting inclusion and respectful participation for children with different abilities and backgrounds within your training and authority;
- communicating routine observations to lead staff, supervisors, or authorized parents/guardians through approved channels;
- following allergy, food-safety, infection-control, emergency, evacuation, and authorized-pickup procedures;
- checking indoor and outdoor areas for obvious hazards and escalating concerns;
- helping children practice social, communication, hygiene, and self-care routines; and
- reporting injuries, behavioral concerns, safeguarding concerns, missing-child risk, unsafe pickup situations, or other urgent issues through the required chain.

What this role must not be presented as

A support role does not automatically authorize independent teaching, clinical, legal, safeguarding, or medical decisions.

Do not independently:

- diagnose developmental, behavioral, psychological, or medical conditions;
- provide therapy, special-education services, nursing assessment, or medical treatment unless separately qualified and authorized;
- administer medication unless current law, employer policy, training, and authorization permit it;
- alter a child's care plan, diet, allergy plan, behavior plan, individualized education plan, or medical instructions without authority;
- use physical restraint, seclusion, punishment, or discipline practices outside approved policy and law;
- decide whether suspected abuse or neglect can be ignored or handled informally when reporting rules apply;
- release a child to an unauthorized person, even if the person claims to be family or says the situation is urgent;

- transport children unless the employer and law specifically authorize the arrangement;
- photograph, record, livestream, post, or privately message children using personal devices or accounts unless explicitly authorized;
- represent yourself as a licensed/certified early childhood educator, lead teacher, nurse, therapist, psychologist, social worker, or other protected professional unless you hold the required credential; or
- bypass emergency, safeguarding, ratio, supervision, or pickup procedures because doing so seems faster or more convenient.

When authority is unclear, stop and ask the responsible supervisor.

Child safeguarding, mandatory reporting, and emergency boundaries

Work with children requires especially strong safeguarding controls. You may observe unexplained injuries, concerning behavior, disclosures, neglect, unsafe pickup attempts, missing-child risk, medical distress, choking, allergic reaction, violence, or other emergencies.

Follow current employer protocol and local law. Depending on the situation, required action may include:

- immediately notifying a supervisor or designated safeguarding lead;
- making a legally required report through the correct channel;
- contacting emergency services when required;
- preserving factual information without conducting your own investigation;
- documenting what was observed or disclosed using objective language;
- maintaining required supervision and child-to-staff ratios during the incident; and
- avoiding promises of secrecy that conflict with child-safety or reporting obligations.

Mandatory-reporting rules vary by jurisdiction, role, setting, and population. Training materials and AI tools do not replace current law or employer policy.

Authorized pickup and child release

Child release is a high-risk control point. Follow the facility's approved identity-verification and pickup authorization process every time.

Do not release a child because someone:

- knows the child's name;

- says they are a relative;
- shows a photo of the child;
- pressures staff because they are in a hurry;
- claims another parent gave verbal permission; or
- asks you to ignore an alert or custody-related restriction.

Escalate discrepancies through the designated supervisor or authorized process.

Health, allergies, food, hygiene, and medication

Childcare environments may involve food allergies, asthma, diabetes, seizures, infectious illness, diapering/toileting, minor injuries, and other health needs.

Follow current written plans and employer rules. Do not improvise treatment or substitute personal judgment for authorized medical instructions.

Depending on jurisdiction and employer policy, workers may need training in first aid, CPR, food safety, infection control, safe sleep, medication assistance, allergy response, or other child-health topics. Verify exact requirements locally.

Privacy, records, photos, and digital safety

Childcare work can involve sensitive information including children's names, addresses, dates of birth, health conditions, allergies, disability information, family circumstances, custody restrictions, emergency contacts, attendance records, photos, videos, and incident reports.

Follow employer rules for:

- collecting only information needed for an authorized purpose;
- using approved childcare, attendance, messaging, and learning systems;
- role-based access and password protection;
- secure parent/guardian communication;
- photo/video consent and media-release rules;
- physical files and sign-in/out records;
- retention and destruction requirements;
- personal devices and messaging apps;
- remote access and mobile devices;
- incident reporting; and
- reporting suspected phishing, account compromise, or unauthorized access.

Never post a child, classroom, schedule, badge, sign-in sheet, incident report, medical information, or custody information on a personal social-media account.

Skills employers may value

Employers often value:

- reliability and punctuality;
- calm supervision;
- age-appropriate communication;
- patience and emotional regulation;
- observation and factual documentation;
- teamwork with educators and families;
- hygiene and safety awareness;
- ability to follow routines consistently;
- inclusive communication;
- conflict de-escalation within approved scope;
- basic digital and recordkeeping skills;
- safeguarding awareness;
- judgment about when to escalate; and
- willingness to complete required background, health, safety, or first-aid training.

Bilingual or multilingual ability may be valuable, but do not claim professional interpretation credentials you do not possess.

Education and entry pathways

United States

Primary occupational mapping: **Childcare Workers, O*NET-SOC 39-9011.00.**

O*NET reports 2025 BLS wage data of:

- **Median hourly wage: USD \$16.82**
- **Median annual wage: USD \$34,980**
- **Employment in 2024: approximately 991,600**
- **Projected openings, 2024-2034: approximately 160,200 per year**
- projected growth characterized by O*NET as decline (-1% or lower).

The BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook reports an older May 2024 median of **USD \$15.41/hour / \$32,050/year**, about **991,600 jobs**, projected decline of **3% from 2024 to 2034**, and approximately **160,200**

openings per year. Keep those dates separate; do not blend the wage series.

BLS states that requirements vary by state and setting. The occupational profile commonly lists high school diploma or equivalent and short-term on-the-job training, but some employers or jurisdictions require early-childhood education, certification, background checks, health requirements, or additional training.

A practical entry sequence is:

1. Review 15–20 current local postings for childcare worker, preschool assistant, teacher aide, daycare assistant, nursery assistant, or similar titles.
2. Record requirements for minimum age, education, background checks, fingerprints, health screening, CPR/first aid, food handling, driving, ratios, and schedule.
3. Separate support jobs from lead-teacher or licensed/certified educator roles.
4. Build supervised experience through childcare, youth programs, camps, community programs, family services, school support, recreation, or caregiving where appropriate.
5. Complete employer-recognized safety and child-development training before paying for expensive private credentials.
6. Apply only to roles that match your real education, experience, screening status, and legal eligibility.

Canada

Closest broad mapping: **Early childhood educators and assistants, NOC 42202.**

Government of Canada Job Bank distinguishes assistants from early childhood educators. Assistants provide care for infants and preschool- to school-age children under the guidance of early childhood educators.

National wage data updated November 19, 2025:

- **CAD \$16.95/hour low**
- **CAD \$22.30/hour median**
- **CAD \$30.03/hour high**

Underlying national wage reference period: 2023–2024 Labour Force Survey data.

Requirements differ by province or territory and between educator and assistant titles. Licensing, certification, registration, education, first aid, or

other conditions may apply. A generic assistant title does not automatically grant educator certification.

Colombia

Primary mapping: **CNO 4311 – Auxiliares de educación para la primera infancia.**

SENA describes this occupation as supporting educational activities under the supervision of an early-childhood educator and lists titles including Asistente de preescolar, Asistente de primera infancia, Auxiliar de jardín infantil, and Auxiliar de preescolar.

Related support mapping: **CNO 6372 – Auxiliares del cuidado de niños**, which includes childcare, feeding, dressing, social and hygiene habits, observations, records, and supervision in childcare or residential contexts.

SENA Betowa lists **Atención integral a la primera infancia**, a technical program of **2,208 hours**. Availability depends on location, modality, cohort, admission process, eligibility, and seats. It is not universally open and should not be described as a universal legal requirement.

Betowa also lists **Estimulación integral en la primera infancia**, a **432-hour** technical-deepening program for people who already have relevant prior education. It is an advanced or adjacent option, not a universal entry requirement.

No clean directly comparable current official national Colombia wage series was established in this research pass. Do not invent one.

Free-first and low-cost training strategy

Before paying for training:

1. Review actual job postings in the target city or jurisdiction.
2. Separate required credentials from preferred credentials.
3. Verify whether the target role is assistant-level or a regulated/credentialed educator role.
4. Ask employers whether they provide paid orientation, safeguarding, CPR/first aid, food-safety, child-development, or classroom-system training.
5. Use public, vocational, community-college, workforce, nonprofit, or employer training first where suitable.
6. Compare total cost, transport, materials, screening, exams, placement hours, and unpaid practicum requirements.
7. Confirm recognition with target employers before enrolling.
8. Get refund, repayment, and job-placement claims in writing.
9. Avoid debt for a credential employers do not request.

Funding and public training locators

United States

CareerOneStop, sponsored by the U.S. Department of Labor, provides American Job Center and training-search tools. WIOA-supported training may be available to eligible individuals, but eligibility, approved programs, priorities, and funding vary locally and are **not guaranteed**.

Search current childcare and early-childhood training options through CareerOneStop and relevant state childcare/licensing agencies.

Canada

Funding and training pathways vary by province or territory. Compare public colleges, provincial employment services, student aid where applicable, employer-supported training, and title-specific certification requirements. Confirm eligibility directly with the responsible program.

Colombia and Latin America

In Colombia, start with SENA/Betowa and SENA employment and occupational resources. In other Latin American countries, identify the relevant national public training institution and verify current childcare/early-childhood programs, recognition, cost, admission rules, and legal scope directly.

Employer support and work-based learning

Ask employers about:

- paid orientation;
- supervised classroom or childcare training;
- safeguarding and mandatory-reporting training;
- CPR and first aid;
- food safety and allergy-response training;
- safe-sleep and hygiene procedures;
- positive behavior-support approaches;
- disability inclusion;
- documentation and parent-communication systems;
- tuition assistance or reimbursement;
- paid practicum or apprenticeship-style learning where available; and
- promotion pathways to senior assistant or credentialed educator roles.

Get repayment obligations in writing before accepting employer-funded education.

Income and employment outlook

United States — official occupational data

Use the current O*NET 2025 BLS wage benchmark as the primary national wage reference for this guide: **USD \$16.82/hour / \$34,980/year**.

Keep the BLS OOH May 2024 wage figure, **USD \$15.41/hour / \$32,050/year**, separately labeled as an older published series. Neither figure guarantees entry-level pay, local wages, hours, benefits, or full-time work.

Canada — official national data

For NOC 42202, national Job Bank data updated November 19, 2025 reports approximately **CAD \$16.95 low, \$22.30 median, and \$30.03 high per hour**. Provincial and regional wages may differ materially.

Colombia

Do not invent a national salary. Use current verified job postings and public employment sources to compare local compensation, schedule, contract type, and credential requirements.

Practical 12-week entry plan

Weeks 1-2: Review 15–20 local postings and record screening, education, age, CPR/first-aid, ratio, schedule, language, and licensing-related requirements.

Weeks 3-4: Study child safeguarding, mandatory reporting, authorized pickup, hygiene, allergy, safe-sleep, and emergency procedures from recognized local sources.

Weeks 5-6: Practice age-appropriate communication, activity setup, factual observation notes, routines, and inclusive support using fictional scenarios.

Weeks 7-8: Complete affordable or employer-recognized CPR/first aid, safeguarding, food safety, child development, or related training where required or useful.

Weeks 9-10: Build supervised experience through a legitimate childcare, school, youth, recreation, community, or family-support setting where permitted.

Weeks 11-12: Apply to roles matching your actual education and credentials. Prepare examples demonstrating reliability, supervision, safety awareness, teamwork, and appropriate escalation.

Building experience without already having the title

Transferable experience may come from:

- supervised childcare;
- youth programs;
- camps and recreation;
- school or classroom support;
- community programs;
- disability-support programs;
- family services;
- library children's programs;
- tutoring or homework support within appropriate boundaries; or
- caregiving experience that can be described accurately.

Do not describe informal babysitting as licensed childcare, claim lead-teacher responsibility you did not have, or claim medical/safeguarding authority beyond your actual role.

Career progression

Possible next steps include senior childcare worker, preschool assistant, classroom aide, early-childhood assistant, program assistant, family-support aide, recreation worker, or other child/youth support roles.

With additional education and jurisdiction-specific credentials, some workers may progress toward certified/licensed early childhood educator, lead teacher, special-needs support, child-development specialist, education, social services, or related careers.

Experience alone does not automatically grant a protected educator title. Verify the legal and educational requirements of the next role before enrolling or presenting yourself under that title.

Responsible use of AI in childcare work

AI may be useful for:

- practicing interview questions;
- explaining general childcare terminology;
- creating fictional activity-planning examples;
- organizing generic study notes; or
- drafting non-sensitive checklists that are then reviewed by a supervisor.

AI must **not** replace child-safeguarding judgment, emergency response, mandatory-reporting duties, authorized-pickup controls, medication

decisions, developmental diagnosis, individualized education decisions, or employer procedures.

Do not enter identifiable child data into a public AI tool, including names, birth dates, photos, videos, health conditions, allergies, disability information, family details, custody information, incident reports, behavioral notes, attendance data, or contact information, unless the organization has expressly approved that system and the required privacy/security controls are in place.

Verify AI-generated activities, safety advice, legal claims, developmental statements, and emergency information before use.

Cybersecurity basics

Childcare facilities may use attendance systems, parent apps, billing systems, shared drives, email, cameras, learning platforms, and mobile devices.

Follow employer rules for:

- multifactor authentication;
- password and credential protection;
- approved devices and applications;
- phishing and suspicious links;
- secure parent communication;
- role-based access;
- camera and recording-system access;
- incident reporting;
- remote work; and
- secure disposal of sensitive records.

Treat urgent requests to change an authorized pickup person, reset a parent account, alter bank/payment information, disclose a child's schedule, or send records to an unexpected address as high-risk. Verify through the approved process before acting.

Avoiding scams and weak training offers

Be cautious when a school, recruiter, or training provider:

- guarantees a childcare job or salary;
- claims a private certificate is legally mandatory without official evidence;
- pressures immediate payment;
- hides total cost, practicum, screening, or refund terms;
- cannot explain which employers recognize the program;

- asks you to pay for a job offer with gift cards, crypto, or wire transfer;
- promises licensure or certification it does not control; or
- requests sensitive identity or banking information before you verify the organization.

Use official government, regulator, employer, public training, or recognized education sources to verify claims.

Current sources

Official/public sources:

- O*NET OnLine — Childcare Workers, 39-9011.00: [Source link](#)
- O*NET OnLine — Childcare Workers details: [Source link](#)
- U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics — Childcare Workers: [Source link](#)
- CareerOneStop — Find Training: [Source link](#)
- Government of Canada Job Bank — NOC 42202 summary: [Source link](#)
- Government of Canada Job Bank — NOC 42202 requirements: [Source link](#)
- Government of Canada Job Bank — NOC 42202 wages: [Source link](#)
- SENA Observatorio — CNO 4311 Auxiliares de educación para la primera infancia: [Source link](#)
- SENA Observatorio — CNO 6372 Auxiliares del cuidado de niños: [Source link](#)
- SENA Betowa — Atención integral a la primera infancia: [Source link](#)
- SENA Betowa — Estimulación integral en la primera infancia: [Source link](#)

Source and review note

This guide uses current-source research recorded on August 20, 2026. Wages, training availability, licensing rules, screening requirements, ratios, first-aid rules, mandatory-reporting obligations, and employer expectations can change. Re-check current official sources before acting.

This controlled revision was produced with AI assistance and auditable source review. It does **not** claim independent human certification, accredited training, certified translation, legal review, childcare licensure approval, safeguarding certification, or guaranteed employment.